

Assessment 3 – Brand Style Guide



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Introduction

The purpose of this brand guide is to help A Hot Hideout to build brand awareness and gain trust from their customers while strengthening their brand's personality and values in order to stay relevant and competitive within the F&B industry in Singapore. This brand guide includes the review of A Hot Hideout's current marketing tactics and overall brand, as well as recommendations that are suitable to further improve the brand's search engine rankings and possibly enhance their customers' experience.

Company Background

A Hot Hideout was founded by a group of NTU students back in 2020, who were passionate about a Chinese cuisine that is popular among Singaporeans, called Mala (A Hot Hideout, 2020). They had a clear goal of making Mala more than just a meal, but an experience to remember. The origin of Mala came from the Sichuan province in China, which is well-known for its bold and spicy cuisine. Aligning with A Hot Hideout's business goal, they have done various research and added local flavours into their dishes to cater to Singaporeans. In order to accommodate a wide range of palates, A Hot Hideout introduced dishes that contain zero spice such as the Oriental Stir Fry, so that Singaporeans can come together and enjoy their meal regardless of spice tolerance. Today, A Hot Hideout has expanded their business across Singapore with a total of 9 outlets.

Customer Persona

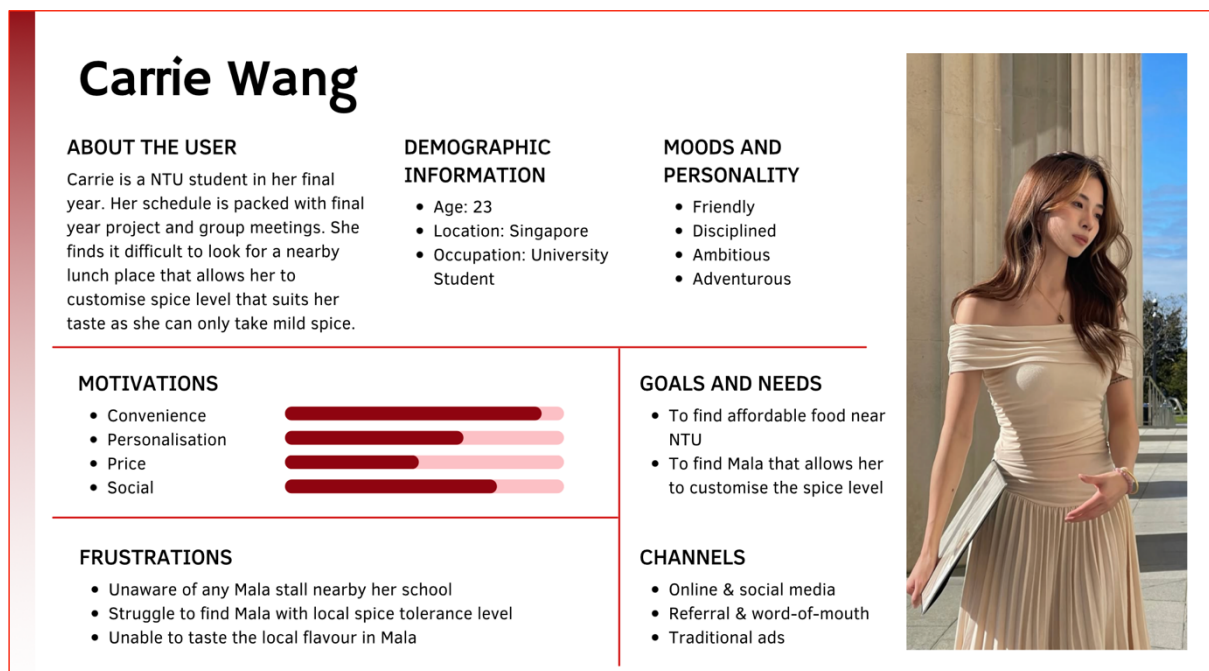


Fig. 1

Based on the customer persona on Fig. 1, A Hot Hideout aims to target:

- People studying in NTU
- People working in NTU
- NTU students and lecturers who want to grab a meal quickly
- NTU students and lecturers who want to customise their soup base and spice level
- NTU students and lecturers who enjoy Singapore's local flavours

As A Hot Hideout expands their business with some outlets having extended opening hours until 2AM, such as the shop located in Kent Ridge. Hence, they also aim to target:

- Foodies who seek to try out unique local flavours
- Local youths who want to enjoy a meal with friends and families
- Influencers who enjoy posting "Instagrammable" items and meals

Brand Guide

Logo



Fig. 2

Fig. 2 shows the existing logo of A Hot Hideout where the brand name is **bold** and **capitalised** in **bright red**. This logo is used generally on their main website and in stores. Using bold on their brand name in all capitals gives their brand a **strong and confident** impression. Furthermore, the use of bright red on their brand name **emphasises the spicy and hot aspect** of the food they are selling. The logo also consists of a bowl icon that is filled with orange-red contents to represent Mala soup. The icon was designed in a simple art style that shows A Hot Hideout's **casual dining** concept. In addition, the colours used in the icon and overall logo design gives a slightly edgy urban feel which makes the brand logo stand out from afar.

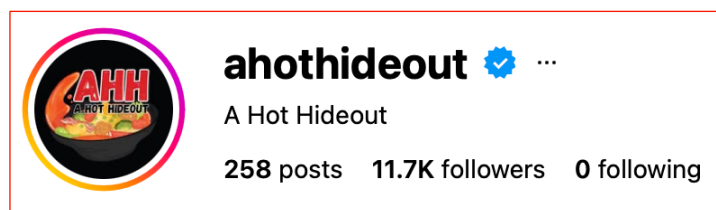


Fig. 3

A Hot Hideout's logo design on their social media page has the full image of a bowl of Mala as shown in Fig. 3. The Chinese characters were also replaced with "AHH" with two possible reasons:

1. "AHH" is the acronym of A Hot Hideout
2. "AHH" can be an expression to describe that the food is spicy and burning hot like a screaming expression

Recommendations

Comparing both of the logo designs above, I personally like their social media's design due to the reasons behind the acronym "AHH" which is unique and can capture their target audience's attention. Although the origin of Mala came from China, A Hot Hideout has positioned themselves as "A Singaporean Kind of Mala". Thus, **adding some local twist** into the logo such as using **English** and the **screaming expression** can make the brand stand out from their potential competition.

It is recommended to **keep the bowl and soup icon** on Fig. 2 while **replacing the Chinese letters with "AHH"**. Moreover, it is crucial for A Hot Hideout to maintain consistency across their website and social media pages to provide clarity and avoid confusion to their customers about their brand.

Recommended icon example from Photoshop:



Colour Palette



Fig. 4

The overall colour palette of A Hot Hideout consists of **bright red, a secondary accent of orange, white, and black**. As seen in their logo as well as their main website, there is a huge colour contrast to ensure that their content and logo title stand out from afar. The colours mentioned are used for different purposes, such as:

- Bright red: Used for **logo title** such as “AHH” and “A HOT HIDEOUT”
- Orange-red: Used for the “**spice**” **effect** in their bowl icon
- White: Used on **texts and brand’s tagline**
- Black: Used as their website’s **background, signage, and store interior**

The use of bright red and orange-red accent help the brand to build on the spicy metaphor by **adding energy and drawing their audience’s attention** to their key elements. Black and white have a **strong contrast** which helps to **increase readability** and gives a modern, bold urban feel that matches their late-night supper time positioning. As seen in Fig. 4, the colour palette chosen for A Hot Hideout allows the brand to be easily recognised due to its colour contrast. Hence, I personally think that A Hot Hideout should continue using this colour palette as it is well chosen and thought of.

Typography



Fig. 5

The current typography used on A Hot Hideout's brand name is in **all-caps with a bold, sans-serif style**. Moreover, the letters are rounded with a thicker weight in red while the tagline "THE SINGAPOREAN KIND OF MALA" is in a narrower uppercase sans-serif font in smaller size to avoid stealing the attention of the brand name above. Both fonts used have **strong readability** as they look **casual and fun** to attract their target audience and position themselves as a casual dining spot for families and friends.

Recommendations



Fig. 6 (Google Fonts, n.d.)

According to the brand's personality of bold, young, and casual, it is recommended to use "**Poppins ExtraBold**" (refer to Fig. 6) for A Hot Hideout's brand name and headers to **leave a stronger impression** of the brand in the mind of their target audience. Based on research (Shu, H., 2024), "Poppins ExtraBold" has bold geometric shapes that appear trendy and lively, expressing creativity and modernism. Moreover, it is generally a popular font used to engage a youthful audience like A Hot Hideout.

This font is strongly recommended for A Hot Hideout as Poppins ExtraBold supports it with:

- The heavy weight **reflects the bold flavours and heat** of Mala
- The rounded letters feel **modern, trendy, and Gen-Z friendly**
- The geometric smoothness **prevents** it from **appearing forceful**
- Strong letterforms make the logo **readable from far** especially for mall signage

Typography example:

A HOT HIDEOUT
A SINGAPOREAN KIND OF MALA

Fig. 7

While keeping the brand name in uppercase for consistency, it is also suggested to **apply red to “HOT”** and black or white to the rest of the words depending on the background colour, to **emphasise on their hot food offerings** as shown above. In addition, A Hot Hideout should **slightly increase their letter-spacing** on the brand name so that the letters can avoid appearing cramped which might increase the difficulty in reading.

The tagline “A SINGAPOREAN KIND OF MALA” can also **adopt the same typography** to ensure **consistency**. However, the font style can be substituted to the “SemiBold” version to ensure that the brand name stands out more. Making the tagline have the same colour as the word “HOT” allows its target audience to understand the meaning behind their brand name while showing that their Mala is as hot as it looks.

Website Design

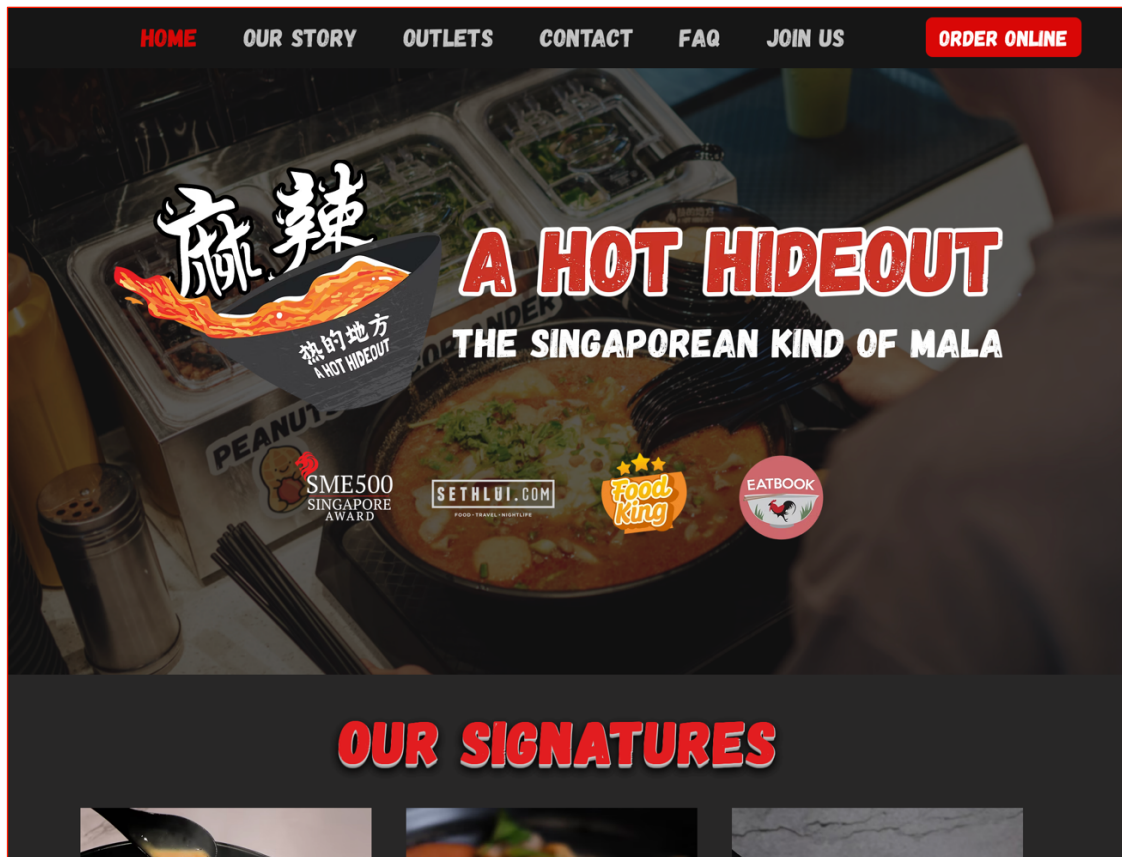


Fig. 8

As shown in Fig. 8, A Hot Hideout's main website is designed with the **same colour palette** that aligns with their brand logo, icon and clear call-to-action (CTA) buttons such as "order online", "menu", and "find us". The website's overall look is **simple yet informative** as the navigation bar above allows their audience to understand their background better with pages such as "our story", "outlets", and "FAQ". A Hot Hideout's website clearly shows that it was **designed with the needs of their customers in mind**.

The bold headline and CTA buttons are **eye-catching** and captures the energy and brand personality of bold, trendy, exclusive, and fun. In order to ensure that their brand stays in the mind of their customers, it is crucial to make their logo outstanding as well.

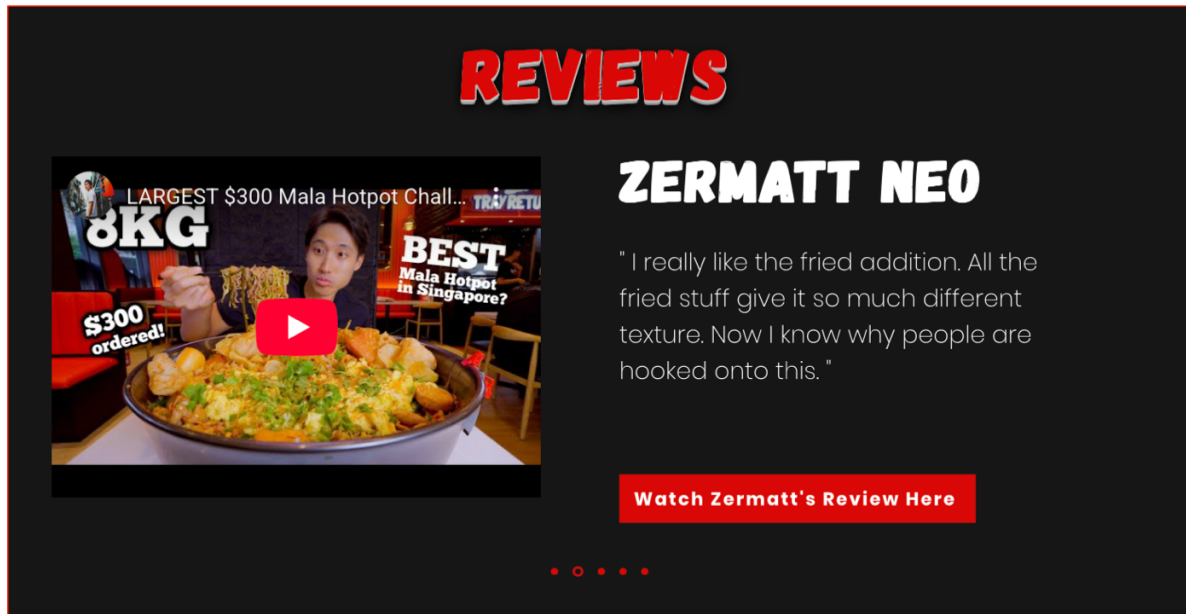


Fig. 9

As a brand that aims to mainly target the local Singaporeans, the first section of the home page (refer to Fig. 8) **presents the award they received and various food review blogs** that A Hot Hideout was featured on such as Sethlui.com and Eatbook.

Furthermore, there are a series of **blog links and YouTube links** as shown in Fig. 9, to direct their users to read or watch more about the **authentic reviews**. These sections help the brand to **build trust with their potential customers** with authentic reviews and testimonials by well-known blog pages.

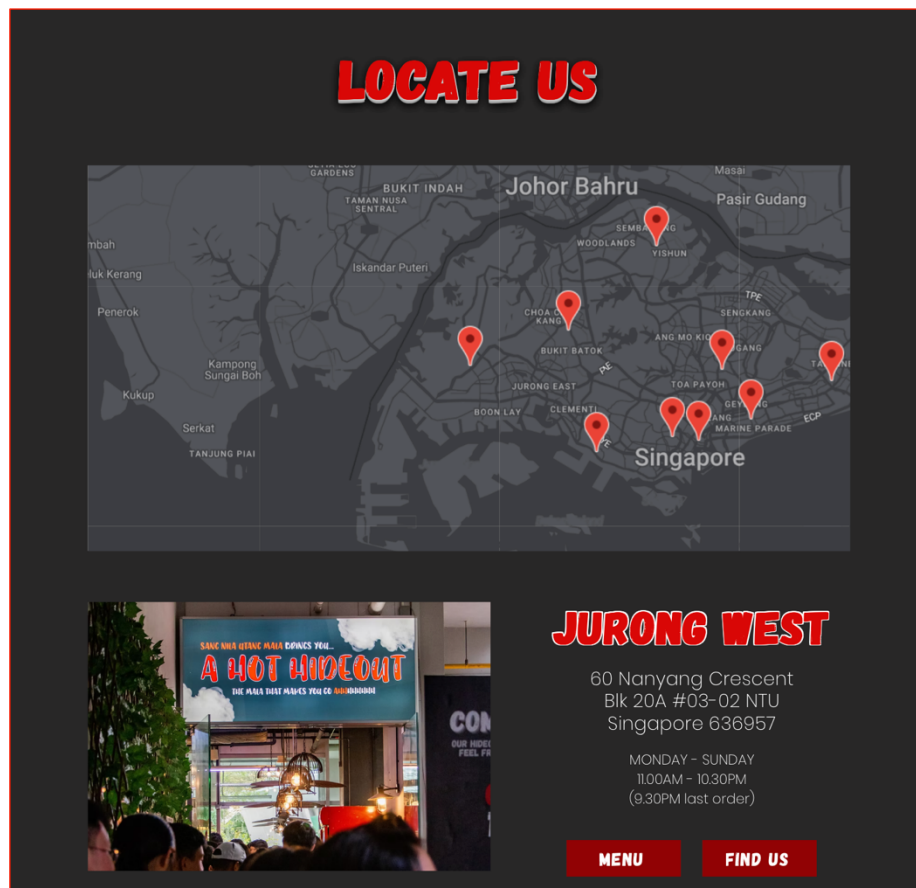


Fig. 10

A Hot Hideout's website visitors can **easily find the locations of their outlets** by either clicking the "outlets" button on the navigation bar or scroll towards the bottom of the home page. The "locate us" section includes a **mini map that zooms out** to the various outlets located in Singapore to **provide clarity** for users to see which outlet is nearer to them. Additionally, they also listed the **details and images for each of their outlets** including the address, operation hours, and the last order's time. By stating all the information clearly can help their users to **avoid confusion** when browsing the website.

Recommendations

It is important for A Hot Hideout to **remain consistent** with their overall theme across all platforms including their website. In order to ensure that the brand's bold, mysterious, and exclusive personality while providing a smooth and exciting user experience, it is recommended to **create a digital "hideout" that feels like an experience**. A Hot Hideout can enhance the design of their website by including **subtle glows or gradients at their dark background** while giving the feeling like entering a secret location which is exclusive to customers.

A Hot Hideout did an amazing job at **adopting the storytelling tactic** that brings their customers on their journey from how they started the business. It is suggested to **continue using this tactic** to create more immersive visuals. They can include a **video or animated background with neon lights flickering, city nightscape, with a slight smoke effect** to further engage their customers that they are a Mala stall that opens for a late night hang out and snacking spot.

Another suggestion is to **include micro-interactions on their CTA buttons**. The bright red buttons are already eye-catchy when placed together with a dark background. However, **adding a glow or pulse** when customers **hover** on the buttons can make the website feel more alive and reactive.

Imagery



Fig. 11

Based on A Hot Hideout's website, the images used shows a **high-contrast theme using warm lighting** to complement the "hot" theme. A Hot Hideout avoids using generic stock images and focus on bold, edgy lifestyle visuals including real images like as shown in Fig. 11, and dynamic people shots such as the background image as shown in Fig. 8 above. According to research (Global Reach, 2024), real images promote trust and community involvement. When brands visually depict actual customer experiences, it humanises the brand while promoting engagement and fostering customer trust. Therefore, the use of imagery on A Hot Hideout's website generally matches the brand personality and aim to build customer trust.

Voice and Tone



Fig. 12

A Hot Hideout's **primary** tone of voice is **confident and energetic** as they use direct and concise headlines. The **secondary** voice and tone A Hot Hideout present are **playful, youthful, and modern** especially on "Our Story" page in Fig. 12 where they showcased how the brand started. They mentioned about their passion when they were young university students trying to figure life out and how they came together to create something unique. In addition, the group photo shown in Fig. 12 represents that they are having fun just like when they were younger despite having a growing business. Thus, it can be shown clearly that their confident and energetic, yet playful and modern tone of voice specifically attracts the younger generations and local Singaporeans who understands them.

Recommendations

It is crucial to refine A Hot Hideout's tone of voice can really strengthen its brand identity and emotional impact. It is recommended for A Hot Hideout to **adopt Singlish terms and Gen-Z slangs** to capture the attentions of locals. Another benefit of adopting Singlish on their website includes building a community where their customers feel engaged and relatable which in return allows them to feel closer to the brand. Additionally, it is proven that website localisation can increase competitive advantage as more organic traffic can be generated by using localised keywords and content to raise search engine rankings in local markets (Aguilar, R., 2025).

Additionally, it is suggested to **emphasise inclusivity** by setting the right tone to the right audience. A Hot Hideout can **create a tagline that make their visitors feel like insiders**. It is recommended for the tagline to be **"Your place. Your people. Your Hideout."** This tagline strongly articulates the ability to involve the community and provide a sense of belonging to its customers.

Positioning

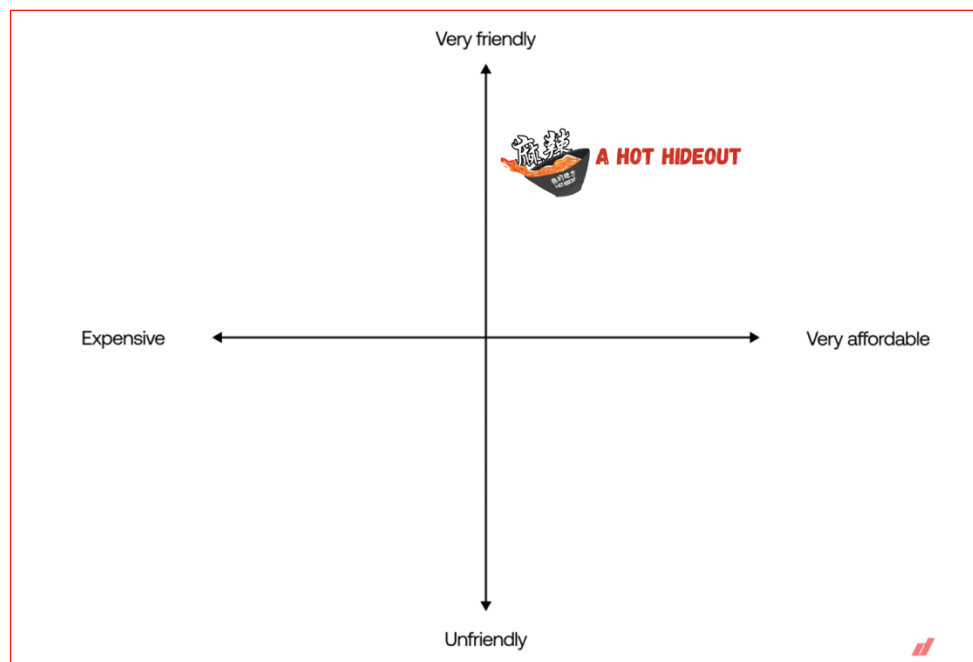


Fig. 13

A Hot Hideout positioned itself as a **very affordable and friendly brand** by offering unique experiences that are memorable and exclusive to Singaporeans (refer to Fig. 13). The brand stands out as it is **trend-conscious and localised** as compared to its competitors. As a young business, A Hot Hideout quickly became one of the most talked about food places in Singapore as customers feel that the brand defines them as their product offerings are catered to their taste. A Hot Hideout's brand positioning of providing exclusive dining experiences to Singaporeans help them to make their products more appealing to the local audience as they worked on researching and understanding the specific needs and user behaviour of their target audience.

A Hot Hideout also positioned itself as a customer-centric brand. From their website design, we can tell that there were various efforts put into ensuring that their website is user friendly and easy to navigate by being direct and informative with their content.

Marketing Materials



Fig. 14

A Hot Hideout initially went viral due to their digital marketing efforts on social media and are constantly active in promoting their brand by partnering with well-known local influencers including Zermatt Neo, a food vlogger on YouTube. Additionally, A Hot Hideout uses different marketing materials including traditional and digital marketing. As shown in Fig. 14, A Hot Hideout uses traditional marketing materials such as posters and flyers with a minimal design. However, it perfectly matches their brand personality and theme with the colours and fun elements in the posters.



Fig. 15

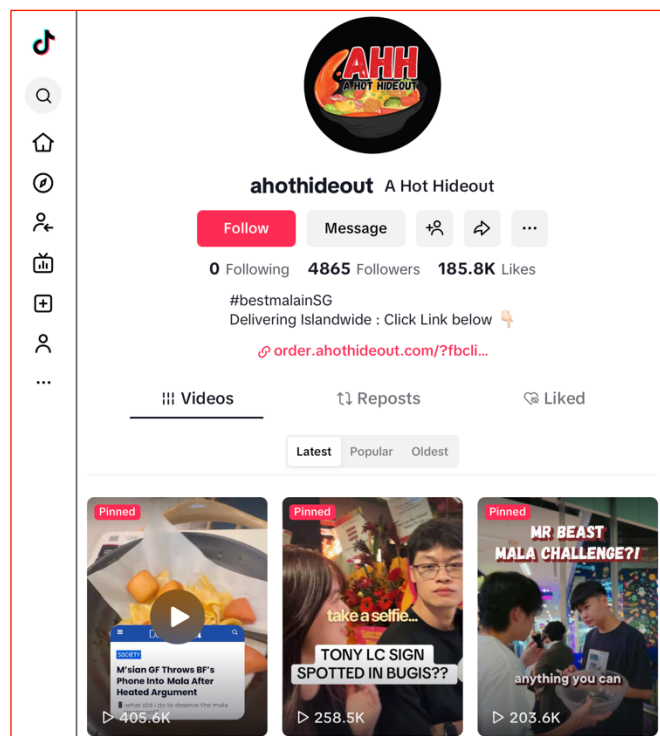


Fig. 16

As mentioned above, A Hot Hideout strongly engages and grow their community through social media platforms including Instagram, TikTok, and Telegram channel. They have 11.8k followers on Instagram and 4865 followers on TikTok. This shows that they managed to reach out to their target audience more effectively on Instagram. As seen in Fig. 15 and 16, A Hot Hideout posted more on Instagram as compared to TikTok because Instagram allows its users to create different types of postings such as short-form video clips and general picture posts, whereas TikTok generally only offer short video posting option.

A Hot Hideout promotes effectively on social media platforms as their target audience of local youths and influencers, generally spend a generous amount of time on social media platform with about 2 hours and 14 minutes on average (Ker, W. Q., 2025). Hence, it is significant to have a strong social media presence as it is highlighted by this high level of engagement to the targeted audience. For instance, A Hot Hideout also updates regularly on their Telegram channel (refer to Fig. 17) about new outlets and hiring notices to ensure that their customers can stay alerted when there are special events.

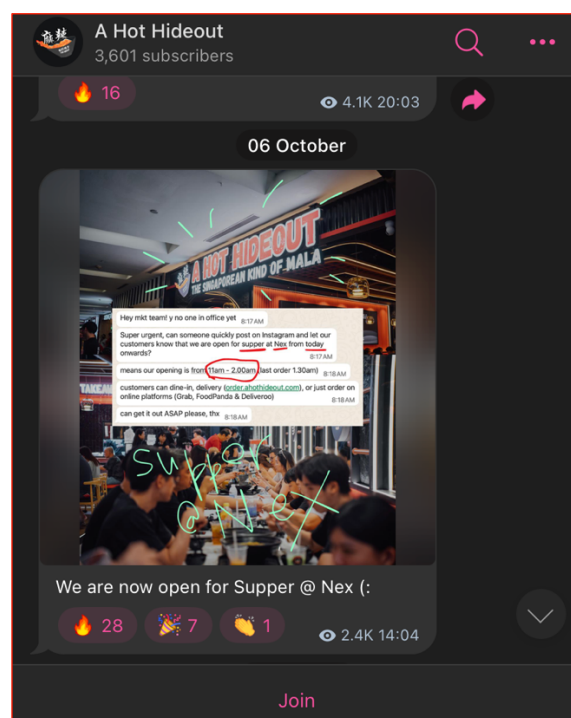


Fig. 17

Conclusion

In conclusion, A Hot Hideout has a strong online presence on their website and social media pages. A Hot Hideout can further improve their website design to boost their search engine ranking. They can also adopt a tone of voice that include their target audience, Singaporean youths. For instance, using Gen-Z slangs and Singlish can promote inclusivity and foster a good community. Additionally, it is very important for A Hot Hideout to remain consistent with their overall theme, brand logo, and tone of voice, to ensure that their customers are clear about their brand purposes.

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